

SESSION 01 OF 20 • THE FITLER MBA ———

The Entrepreneurial Mindset

Two muscles. One yellow pad. Begin it now.

• 90 MINUTES • FRAMEWORKS + WORKSHOP • IDEA FORGE LIVE

Welcome *back.*

LAST WEEK • SESSION 00

We said the room is the curriculum.

And we promised to do real work between sessions — write briefs, not wishes. Post problems. Talk to each other. Tonight, we start building on it.

IF YOU HAVEN'T POSTED YET, NO SHAME — START TONIGHT

X

posts in the *Problems* category

PROBLEMS YOU NAMED, LOOKING FOR A PARTNER

Y

prompts in *Show Your Work*

REAL RTCEF RUNS FROM YOUR WORK WEEK

Z

2036 Forbes drafts *incoming*

WE'LL READ THREE OF THESE NEXT WEEK, IN SESSION 02

FIRST PRINCIPLE

A startup is a *temporary* thing.

It exists to find something. Once it finds it, the startup ends — and the company begins. If you confuse the two, you'll run the wrong playbook.

"A startup is a temporary organization designed to search for a repeatable and scalable business model."

STEVE BLANK · THE FOUR STEPS TO THE EPIPHANY

PHASE 01

The *search*



THE UNLOCK

Product-market fit

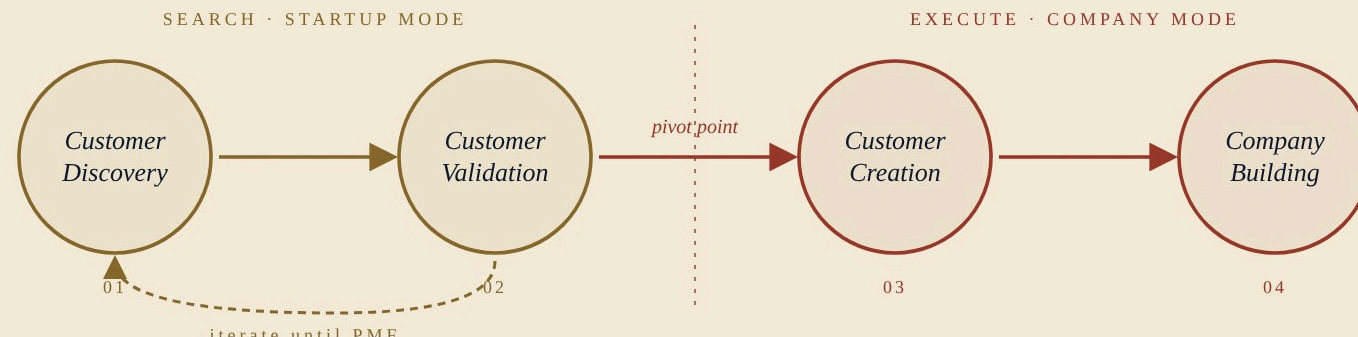


PHASE 02

The *execute*

Search vs. execute.

STEVE BLANK'S CUSTOMER DEVELOPMENT MODEL • THE SPINE OF LEAN STARTUP



SEARCH • STARTUP MODE

Finding the *unknown*

- Hypotheses, not plans
- Customer interviews, not customer support
- Throw it out and try again
- Measured in learnings per week
- Founder-led, ambiguity-tolerant
- "Are we onto something?"

EXECUTE • COMPANY MODE

Scaling the *known*

- Plans, budgets, OKRs
- Process, repeatability, predictability
- Optimize the engine you've got
- Measured in revenue, retention, margin
- Management-led, ambiguity-averse
- "Are we hitting the number?"

Think like a VC.

Even if you'll never take outside money. Every idea you consider is an *investment* — of your time, your reputation, your next five years. The math should change how you decide.



VCs need 10x winners to cover the losers in their portfolio. You only have one portfolio — yours.

The corporate *unlearn*.

You didn't get to where you are by accident. The reflexes that made you successful in a big org will quietly sabotage you in a startup. Four to swap, starting tonight.

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|-----------|--|---|---|
| <i>i.</i> | Build consensus before deciding | → | Make the call with <i>70%</i> of the info |
|-----------|--|---|---|
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|------------|-----------------------------------|---|--|
| <i>ii.</i> | Polish before shipping | → | Ship the <i>ugly</i> version, learn faster |
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| <i>iii.</i> | Protect the downside | → | Optimize for the <i>upside</i> |
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| <i>iv.</i> | Headcount equals power | → | <i>Leverage</i> equals power |
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Five rules from *Kessler*.

Andy Kessler ran a hedge fund and wrote one of the most useful "how the world actually works" books for entrepreneurs. The whole book is ten rules. These five are the ones that change how you see an opportunity.

i. If it doesn't *scale*, it'll go stale.

Boutiques are lovely; they don't compound. Look for things that can grow without breaking.

ii. Waste what's *abundant* to make up for what's scarce.

Compute is cheap. Attention is expensive. Spend the cheap thing freely to save the dear one.

iii. Intelligence moves to the *edge* of the network.

Power flows away from centers, toward users. Build for the edge, not the hub.

iv. Embrace *exceptionalism*.

Average is the enemy. Find the outlier customers, the outlier markets, the outlier you.

Where ideas *come from*.

Not from staring at a blank page. Ideas live in places — you have to know where to look. Four sources, in roughly the order of how often they pay off.

i. Solve a problem *you* have.

HIGHEST HIT RATE

The frustration you've ranted about three times this month. The hack you built for yourself. The thing you'd pay someone to fix. Founder-market fit starts here — you already understand the pain, the language, the workaround, the urgency.

ii. *Observe* and research.

PATIENCE REQUIRED

Watch where people waste time. Read trade publications outside your field. Listen for "I wish there was a way to..." Pain points hide in plain sight when you're looking for them — most people stopped noticing years ago.

iii. Have a *conversation* with Claude.

NEW MUSCLE

Tell it about your experience, your skills, your network. Ask what problems are adjacent. Ask what's underserved. Use it as a thinking partner, not an answer machine — your job is to push back on whatever it suggests.

The four *questions*.

If you can't answer all four, you don't have a business — you have a feeling.

01. What *problem* do you solve?

Specific, not abstract. "People are lonely" is not a problem. "New retirees lose their daily structure within 90 days of stopping work" is. The sharper the framing, the more obvious the test.

02. Who's *got* it?

Name the segment. Estimate the size. If you say "everyone," you're hand-waving. Sharp tribes beat broad markets every single time — narrow your way to clarity.

03. What's the *impact* of the problem today?

Urgency and pain magnitude. Is it costing them money? Time? Relationships? Sleep? The more vivid the answer, the better the opportunity. "Mildly annoying" is a no.

04. Who's *willing to pay* to make it

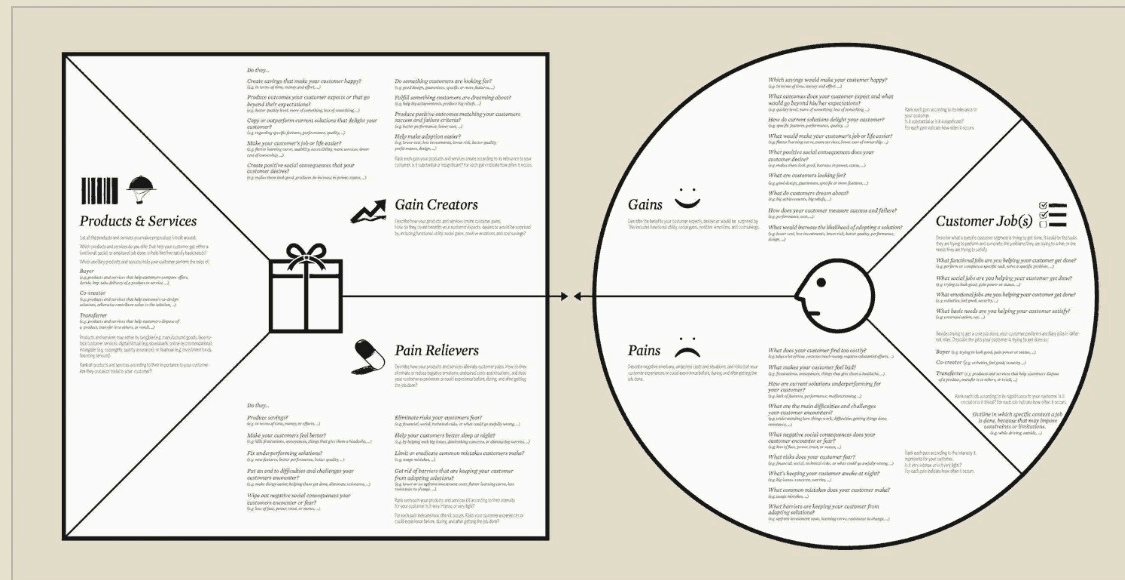
Sometimes the payer isn't the user. Sometimes the user is broke. The opportunity is where the pain meets a budget — that intersection is where

A taste of two we'll see again.

Tonight is the conceptual scaffold. These two frameworks will become tools in later sessions — but you should recognize them now, so they feel familiar when we land on them.

FRAME • SEE AGAIN IN SESSION 02

Value Proposition Canvas



Osterwalder's framework for mapping what your product does against what your customer actually wants. Two halves: the customer profile (jobs, pains, gains) and your value proposition (products, pain relievers, gain creators). When the two halves match, you have fit.

→ DEEP DIVE • SESSION 02 • PROBLEM-SOLUTION FIT

Five ways to *enter*.

Before you know your customers, you should know your *market posture*. Each of these is a different game, with different risks, different timelines, and different definitions of winning. Pick consciously.

i. New product, *new* market

You're inventing the category. Highest risk, highest reward. You'll spend years educating customers before they know they need you.

SPACEX · ANTHROPIC

ii. New product, *existing* market

Customers already buy something here. You're offering them a better way. Faster path to revenue, but you'd better actually be better.

TESLA · STRIPE

iii. *Resegment* an existing market

The market exists, but you're carving out a sharper slice — a niche, a price point, a use case nobody serves well. Often the smartest play.

LULULEMON · LIQUID DEATH

iv. New *low-cost* provider

Same product class, dramatically cheaper. Forces operational excellence. Works when the incumbents have gotten lazy or expensive.

VANGUARD · COSTCO

WHICH ONE ARE YOU PLAYING? YOU SHOULD KNOW

v. *Geographic* replication

A model proven in one place, brought somewhere new. Lower-risk

UBER · AIRBNB (11/Y)¹⁹

Three of *my* current bets.

Watch the *method*, not the answers. The point isn't that you should chase these. The point is the questions I ran each one through to decide it was worth thinking about.

— WORKED EXAMPLE · USE THE METHOD, NOT THE PICKS

i. EV battery *recycling*

The first wave of EVs is hitting end-of-life. Lithium, cobalt, nickel — all scarce, all in those packs. The recyclers who solve the chemistry now will own the supply chain in ten years.

WHY NOW

FIRST BIG COHORT OF EV
BATTERIES HITS RETIREMENT

FOUNDATION · IMPACT ****

ii. The *aging* population

The largest generation in human history is becoming the oldest. Caregiving, cognitive support, end-of-life dignity — every part of this is underserved. Boomers will pay for what works.

WHY NOW

DEMOGRAPHIC CERTAINTY,
SOFTWARE GAP OBVIOUS

FOUNDATION · TRIBE SHARP

iii. Attacking *data-intensive* industries

Insurance, healthcare, legal, finance — industries that drown in data but extract little signal. AI doesn't just speed them up; it changes what's possible. The incumbents move slowly.

WHY NOW

AI CROSSED A CAPABILITY
THRESHOLD, MOATS SOFTENING

FOUNDATION · PAIN OLD, SOL'N
NEW

One *yellow pad*.

If you only take one thing from tonight, take this. Buy an 8.5 × 14 yellow legal pad. Put it where you start your day. Then run this protocol for six weeks. The results will surprise you.

i. Capture, don't *think*.

One-line problem or idea description. No editing, no judging, no "is this any good." Speed beats quality at this stage.

ii. Commit to *five a day*.

Five new entries every single day. Some days they'll be brilliant. Most days they'll be junk. That's the point — you can't tell from inside the moment.

iii. Once a week, *review*.

Sit down on Sunday. Read everything you wrote. Star the ones that still feel alive. Ignore the others — no shame, just data.

iv. Page full? *Rank*.

When you fill a page, score your starred items against the Four Foundation Questions. The top three move to the next page.

	MON · 7:14 AM · PG 03
	— Solo lawyers · doc review ★
	— Tracking parents' meds ★
	— EV battery recyclers ★
	— Better airport lounges
	— AI triage for claims adjusters
	— Retired trades going solo
	— SMB CFO-as-a-service ★
	— "Uber but for X" no
	— Onboarding contractors
	— HOA software (the worst)



Ten *minutes*.

Refill. Hit Discourse. We come back to do the work —
your one-line problem, sharpened live.

Your yellow pad, *sharpened*.

Built for tonight. It runs your one-liner through the Four Foundation Questions, scores it honestly, and gives you a tactical investigation plan for the week. Powered by Claude Opus 4.7 under the hood.

STAGE 01

Capture the one-liner

Same as the yellow pad. One sentence, no editing.

STAGE 02

Claude *interviews* you

2-3 sharpening questions per Foundation Question. You answer; the gaps are also data.

STAGE 03

The *forge*

A sharpened thesis, four scores out of ten, strengths and weaknesses called out plainly.

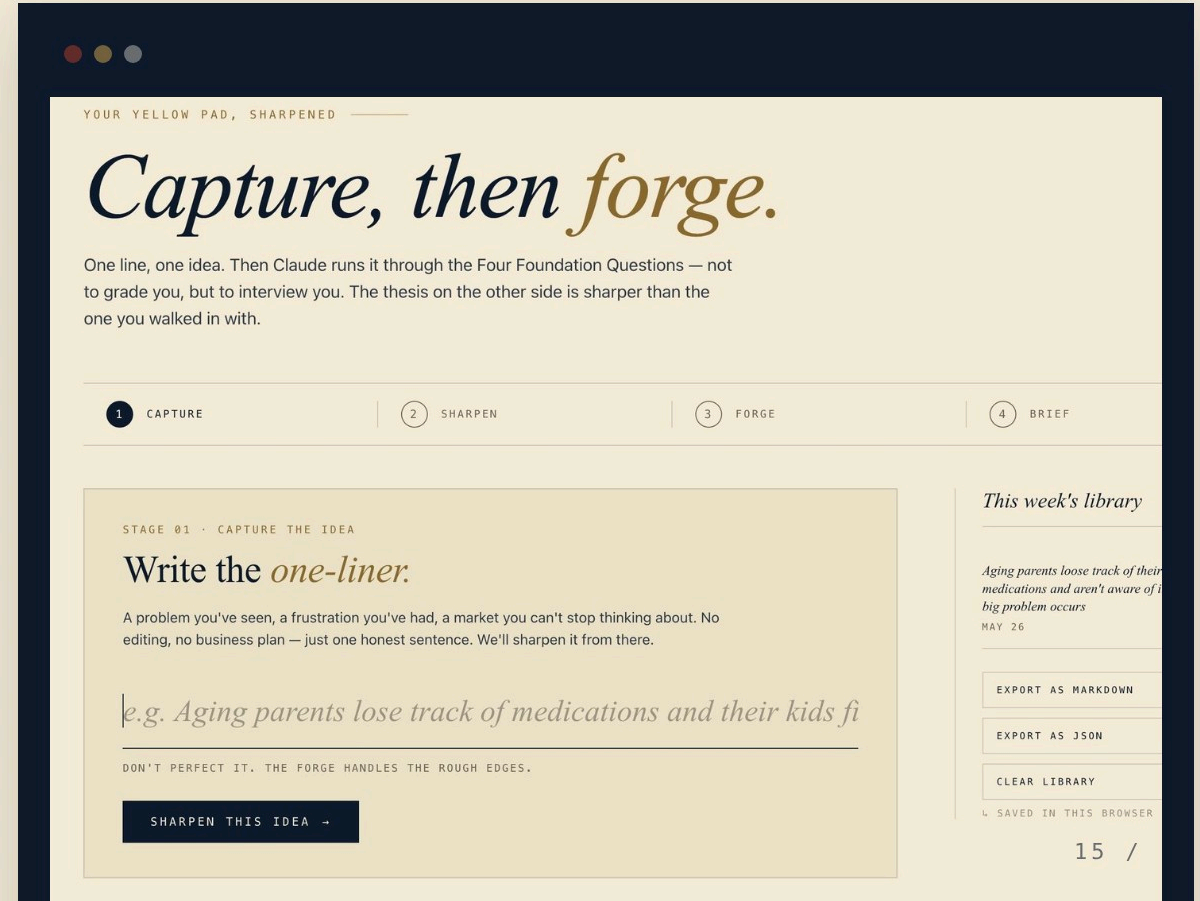
STAGE 04

The *playbook*

For any dimension scored 6 or below: a tactical 5-day investigation plan. Specific people to talk to, specific things to test.

TRY IT. THE HARD PART IS STARTING

STAGE 05



Now *you* drive.

Open Idea Forge. Pick a problem the aging population actually has. Run it through the forge. Bring the brief back.

THE PROMPT

"Pick one specific problem facing the aging population — a real problem, not a category — and forge it into a thesis you'd actually defend."

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- 01 Be *specific*. Not "loneliness." Pick a narrow tribe — newly-widowed men, adult children of dementia patients, retired tradespeople. The narrower, the sharper.
 - 02 Don't *solve* it on the way in. The Forge is for sharpening problems, not for proposing solutions. The solution comes after you understand the pain.
 - 03 Answer the sharpening questions *honestly*. If you don't know, say so. "I don't know" is more useful than a guess that flatters you.
 - 04 Take the *brief*. The output is a one-page document. Screenshot it or download the markdown. You'll need it for Session 02.

What did the *forge* reveal?

Not a presentation round — a conversation. I'll throw questions at the room. Anyone can answer. Volunteers welcome, calling on you also welcome. The goal is to make the experience visible to everyone.

i. Which Foundation Question *caught* you?

Where did the sharpening questions force you to admit you didn't actually know the answer? That's the gap to investigate.

ii. What's the lowest score you got — and was it *fair*?

Be honest. Did Claude catch real hand-waving, or did it miss something specific to your context? Both are useful to surface.

iii. Does your *sharpened thesis* still feel like yours?

Sometimes the forge produces a tighter version. Sometimes it pushes you somewhere you didn't intend. What happened to your idea between input and output?

iv. What's the *first move* on your brief — and will you actually do it?

Three things, *specific* deadlines.

Session 02 is Problem-Solution Fit. We're going to workshop the three problems with the most heat from Discourse. To earn a spot in the room next week, do the work.

i. Start the *yellow pad*.

Five new entries every day. Buy the pad tonight. Start tomorrow morning before checking email. Post a photo of your first page to the Show Your Work category by the weekend.

— DUE · SUNDAY EOD

ii. Run *three* ideas through the Forge.

Not just the aging-population one from tonight. Pick two more — anything that's been nagging at you. Save all three to your library. Post your best brief to Show Your Work.

— DUE · WEDNESDAY

iii. Engage on *Discourse*.

FITLER.UBA.COM · PROBLEMS · SHOW YOUR WORK

Add your introduction posting if you haven't already, and share comments about your search for an idea and suggestions for improving the

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*"Whatever you can do, or
dream you can do — **begin it.**
Boldness has genius, power,
and magic in it."*

GOETHE · STILL RIGHT

See you in two weeks.